needed to be “quieted”—that is, they had to either surrender to the Haganah or be evacuated and destroyed.

It must be emphasized that “Plan D” was prepared on the basis of military considerations and by military commanders, not by politicians. The formulators of the plan did not work on the basis of any political directive to expel the Arabs of the Land of Israel. The plan determined, for the first time in the history of the Haganah, that villages and towns should be either conquered and held or destroyed. The occupied areas were to be searched for weapons and irregular forces. *If resistance was encountered, the armed forces were to be annihilated, the residents were to be expelled, and a garrison was to be stationed in the village.* In some of the brigades’ operational orders, commanders were granted the discretion to “seize or destroy” as they saw fit. At that stage of the war, even before the declaration of the state, the reality on the ground was such that few of the commanders actually had to deal with this dilemma, as most of the Arabs did not wait for an expulsion order—they fled on their own initiative.

Until April 1948, there was no sign of a general policy of expelling Arabs in any of the institutions of the Yishuv. The mass flights of the Arabs surprised even the hawks among the Yishuv’s leadership. Reading the documents from that period, one is struck by the sense of uneasiness felt throughout the ranks of the Jewish leadership, from Ben-Gurion downwards, which reflected a dilemma that contained a clear tragic element—the recognition that for the sake of ensuring the sovereign existence of the Jewish people in its land there was no option but to change the demographic balance but, at the same time, the feeling that all those involved in this matter were doing so reluctantly and with displeasure. Here and there, one can find expressions of relief voiced by the leaders of the Yishuv regarding the Arab flight, for example Ben-Gurion and Israel Galili, who said that the Arabs “made it easier for us” or “did the work for us.” The ideological Left, represented most prominently by Mapam, advocated a binational state but reluctantly accepted the flight of the Arabs and the prevention of their return. Ideology and land are apparently two separate matters—Mapam’s Hashomer Hatzair kibbutz movement saw no ideological barrier to taking control of the Arabs’ lands after they fled, in many cases also taking over the lands of villages whose residents were expelled. Particularly conspicuous is the case of Kibbutz Bar’am, which was built on land belonging to the village of Bir’am, whose residents were